hair. His nose was certainly sharper than his intellect. He, too, made Biblical references. At least ten other officials came and went during the next few days of interrogation. A couple of them, whom I understood were from R&AW, were more matter of fact and reassuring that the truth will come out sooner than later. The R&AW men did not torture me.

The first to interrogate me were the ones who called themselves *Satya* and *Dharma*; two other men in vests and shorts stood behind me. It did not take long before I realised the two men had taken positions behind me to land blows on the small of my neck.

The senior began thus: 'You are a brilliant scientist, an excellent manager, a national asset. So why did you do this?

'What did I do?'

'Espionage.'

'What espionage?'

He cleared his throat. 'Mr Nambi … sorry, Dr Nambi …'

'No, I am not Dr Nambi, mister suits me fine.'

'That's okay, you are as good as a doctor,' the man assumed a satirical tone. 'Now tell me why did you do this crime?'

'Please understand,' I replied. 'I have done no crime. What is it that you really want?'

'Don't bullshit. If you confess, your life will be easy; otherwise we know how to make you confess.'

That was the first sign of a threat.

'What is my crime?'

'You don't know?' Now he stood up and sat down again. 'We have proof that you sold the nation's secrets, rocket technology to Pakistan. Now we want to hear that from your mouth. Tell us how did you do it? How much filthy money did you get?'

At this point, three others walked into the room. One wore a grey safari suit and was introduced by a thin, short person as 'the biggest man in IB'.

Then suddenly, the thin man with a poke-marked face shouted at me.

'You bastard, do you know what the charges against you are?'